

ESTONIA COUNTY

ECONOMIC LIVABILITY

Comparative analysis of income, housing affordability and labour-market conditions

Decision question: Which Estonian county offers the strongest economic conditions for a resident relying on local earnings and market housing?

Report type	Analytical portfolio report
Geographic scope	15 Estonian counties
Data coverage	2021–2026, with metric-specific reference periods
Version	1.0 — 1 August 2026

Scope note. The report measures economic livability. It does not measure total quality of life, public services, safety, transport, health, education or environmental conditions.

Executive Summary

This report compares the economic conditions of Estonia's 15 counties using wage, housing and labour-market data. The reference case is a resident relying on local gross earnings and a 50 m² apartment in the private market. The analysis combines five relative component scores: income, rental affordability, purchase affordability, employment security and job opportunity.

Järva ranks first with an Economic Livability Score of 79.0. Its result is not driven by a single extreme value. Järva combines the third-highest median gross wage, a rental burden below 20% of gross median wage, a purchase-price ratio of 1.22 annual median wages, 6.0% unemployment and an above-median vacancy rate. It remains first under all four tested weight scenarios.

Põlva and Jõgeva rank second and third. Jõgeva has the lowest estimated rental burden and a strong vacancy rate, but its unemployment rate is high. Põlva is less extreme and ranks well across several components. Harju has the highest median wage and vacancy rate but ranks seventh because a 50 m² apartment is estimated to absorb 35.7% of median gross wage and cost 5.33 annual median wages. Tartu shows a similar, though less severe, housing trade-off.

Rental affordability improved relative to 2021 in 13 of the 14 counties with usable rent observations: median gross wages grew faster than asking rents. Saare is the only exception, but its rent series is sparse and receives a low-confidence flag. Hiiu is not ranked because the supplied files contain no apartment-rent observations and no 2024 unemployment value; missing data are not treated as zero.

The result should be used as a comparative screening tool, not as a universal relocation recommendation. The score is relative, the weights are normative, gross wages overstate disposable income, asking rents are not signed contracts, and purchase prices are based on cumulative 2021–2025 transactions rather than a current-month market estimate.

Table 1. Principal findings

Question	Answer
Best balanced county	Järva, score 79.0; first under every tested weighting scenario.
Highest income	Harju, €1,992 median gross wage per month; Tartu second at €1,860.
Lowest rental burden	Jõgeva, 17.7% of median gross wage for the 50 m ² scenario.
Best purchase affordability	Ida-Viru, 0.84 annual median wages for the 50 m ² scenario.
Lowest unemployment	Viljandi, 4.8% in the 2024 three-year moving-average measure.
Strongest employer demand	Harju, 2.13% latest four-quarter average vacancy rate.
Insufficient data	Hiiu: no usable apartment-rent series and no 2024 unemployment value.

Source: Derived county snapshot from the supplied official and market datasets.

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1. Purpose and Analytical Questions

The purpose of the analysis is to identify counties that offer a strong economic balance for residents. The term economic livability is restricted to three dimensions: earnings, housing affordability and labour-market conditions. Population is used for context and transaction-liquidity measures, but it does not contribute directly to the score.

The report is designed for comparative screening. It answers the following questions:

- Which counties rank highest on a combined Economic Livability Score?
- Where does a median gross wage buy the most housing?
- Where is renting a 50 m² apartment least burdensome relative to median gross wage?
- Which counties combine low unemployment with strong employer demand?
- Are wages rising faster than apartment asking rents?
- Which housing markets contain enough observations for the estimates to be credible?
- Which component explains each county's rank?
- Where are the data too sparse for a responsible conclusion?

Interpretation rule: A high overall score indicates a favourable balance within the variables included in this report. It does not establish that the county is the best place to live for every household.

2. Data and Method

2.1 Data sources and coverage

The analysis uses four Statistics Estonia tables, the KV.ee price-statistics calculator and the Maa- ja Ruumiamet real-estate transaction database. The reporting periods differ by source, so each metric is labelled with its own reference period.

Table 2. Data sources

Dataset	Measure	Grain	Coverage	Use in report
PA119	Median gross wage	County-month	2021-01 to 2026-03	Income level and wage trend
TT443	Unemployment rate, three-year moving average	County-year	2019–2024	Employment security
PAV014	Job vacancies and occupied posts	County-quarter	2012 Q1 to 2026 Q1	Vacancy rate and employer demand
RV022U	Population at 1 January	County-year	2023	Context and transaction-rate denominator
KV.ee	Apartment asking rent and listing activity	County-month	2021-01 to 2026-07	Rental affordability and data depth
Maa- ja Ruumiamet	Apartment transactions and prices by area band	County-size band	2021-01-01 to 2025-12-31	Purchase affordability and liquidity

Source: Statistics Estonia [1–4], KV.ee [5], Maa- ja Ruumiamet [6–7].

2.2 Reference case and derived measures

The reference case uses a 50 m² apartment. This standardises the housing comparison and avoids comparing counties through different average apartment sizes. It is a scenario, not a claim about the housing needs of every household.

$$\text{Rental burden} = (\text{asking rent per m}^2 \times 50) \div \text{median monthly gross wage} \times 100 \quad (1)$$

$$\text{Purchase ratio} = (\text{transaction median price per m}^2 \times 50) \div (\text{median monthly gross wage} \times 12) \quad (2)$$

Income is the average of the latest 12 monthly median gross-wage observations through March 2026. Rent is the average of the latest 12 available months through July 2026. The vacancy indicator is the average of the latest four quarters through 2026 Q1. Unemployment is the 2024 value from TT443, which is a three-year moving average. Apartment purchase prices use the cumulative county median for 2021–2025.

2.3 Scoring model

Each component is converted to a percentile score from 0 to 100. Higher values are better for income and vacancy rate. Lower values are better for rental burden, purchase ratio and unemployment. The overall score is a weighted sum of the five components.

$$\text{Overall score} = 0.25 \text{ Income} + 0.25 \text{ Rent} + 0.15 \text{ Purchase} + 0.20 \text{ Employment} + 0.15 \text{ Vacancies} \quad (3)$$

Table 3. Baseline scoring weights

Component	Weight	Direction	Operational measure
Income level	25%	Higher is better	Latest 12-month average median gross wage
Rental affordability	25%	Lower burden is better	Estimated 50 m ² monthly rent / median gross wage
Purchase affordability	15%	Lower ratio is better	Estimated 50 m ² price / annual median gross wage

Component	Weight	Direction	Operational measure
Employment security	20%	Lower unemployment is better	2024 county unemployment rate
Job opportunity	15%	Higher is better	Latest four-quarter average vacancy rate

The baseline score is calculated only for counties with all five components. No missing value is replaced with zero or imputed from another county. Hiiu therefore remains unranked.

2.4 Data-confidence rule

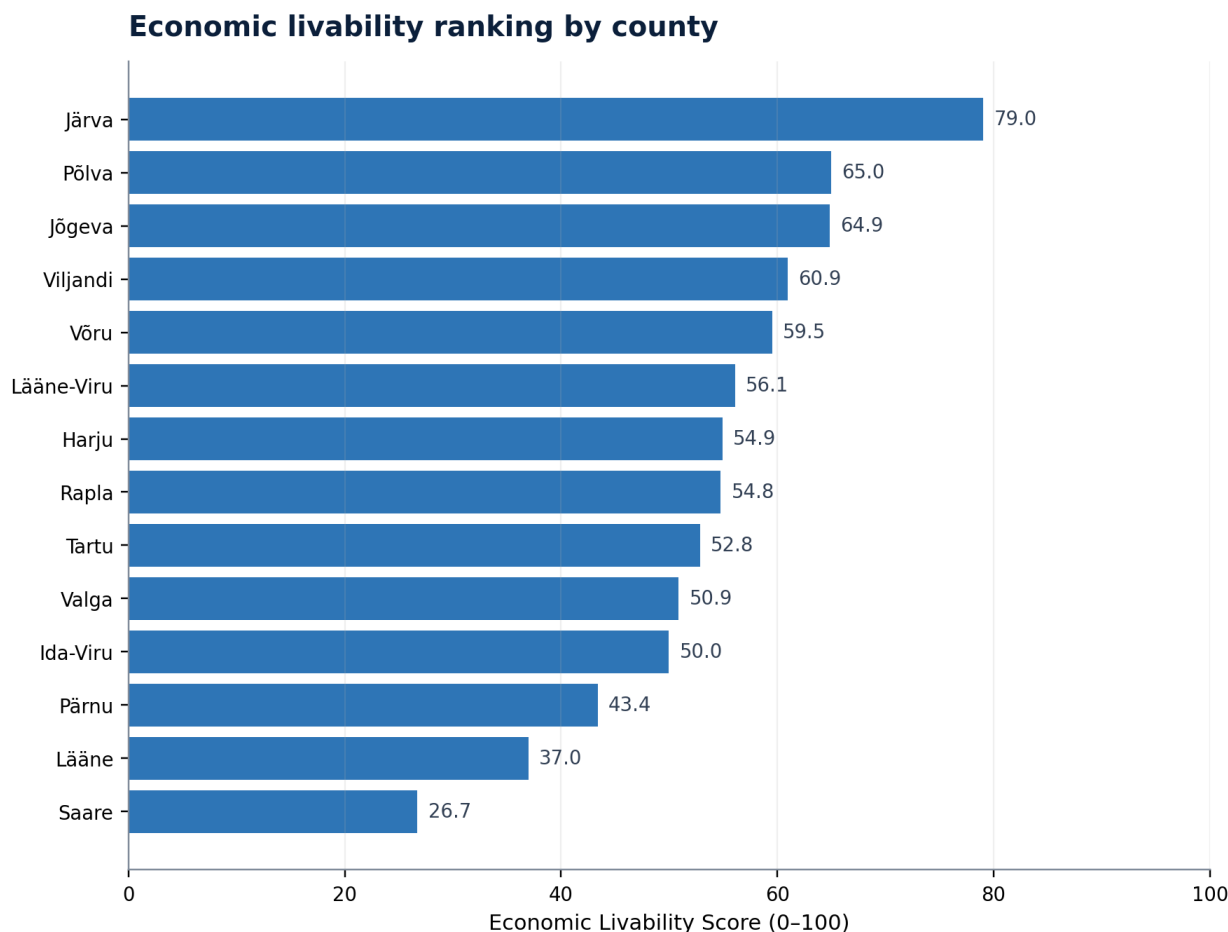
A county receives a low-confidence flag when any score input is missing or fewer than nine recent rent months are available. A complete county with fewer than ten advertisements per month on average receives a medium flag. Other complete counties receive a high flag. This flag describes data coverage, not the economic quality of the county.

3. Findings

3.1 Overall ranking: Järva has the strongest balance

Järva ranks first with a score of 79.0, 14.0 points above Põlva and 14.2 points above Jõgeva. The gap is explained by balance: Järva places in the upper half of every component and has no major penalty. It is third in income, fourth in rental affordability, fifth in purchase affordability, fourth in employment security and fifth in job opportunity.

Põlva and Jõgeva reach similar overall scores through different profiles. Põlva is relatively balanced. Jõgeva has the best rental-affordability score and the second-highest job-opportunity score, but its 9.3% unemployment rate materially reduces the result.



Note: Hiiu is unranked because the supplied data lack rent observations and a 2024 unemployment value.

Figure 1. Economic Livability Score by county.

Source: Derived from PA119, TT443, PAV014, KV.ee and Maa- ja Ruumiamet data.

3.2 The ranking is driven by trade-offs, not a single dominant county

Harju is first in income and job opportunity, but last in both housing-affordability components. Tartu is second in income and third in employment security, but its rental and purchase burdens are among the highest. Ida-Viru is first in purchase affordability and second in rental affordability, but last in employment security. Viljandi has the lowest unemployment rate but only mid-table housing and vacancy scores.

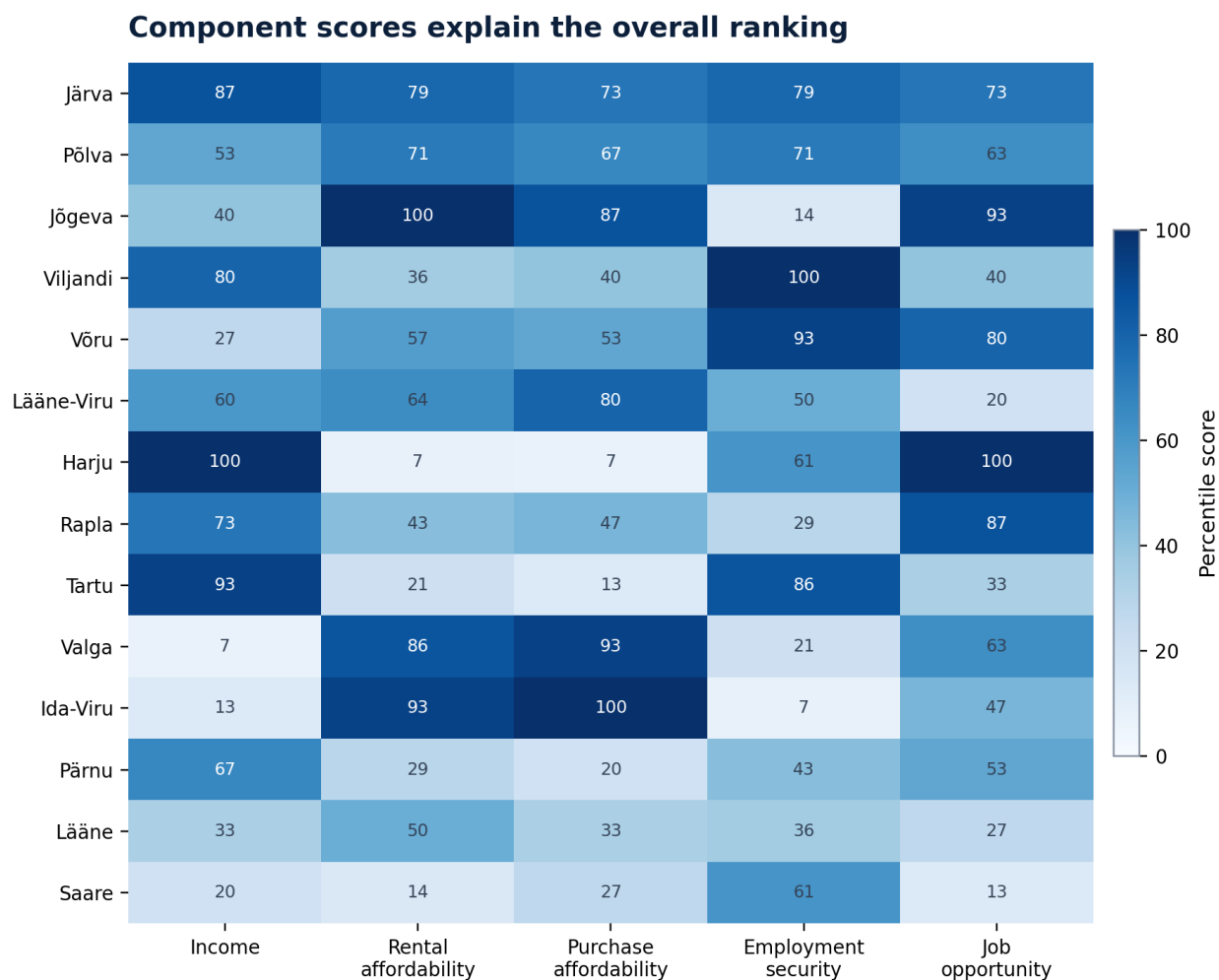


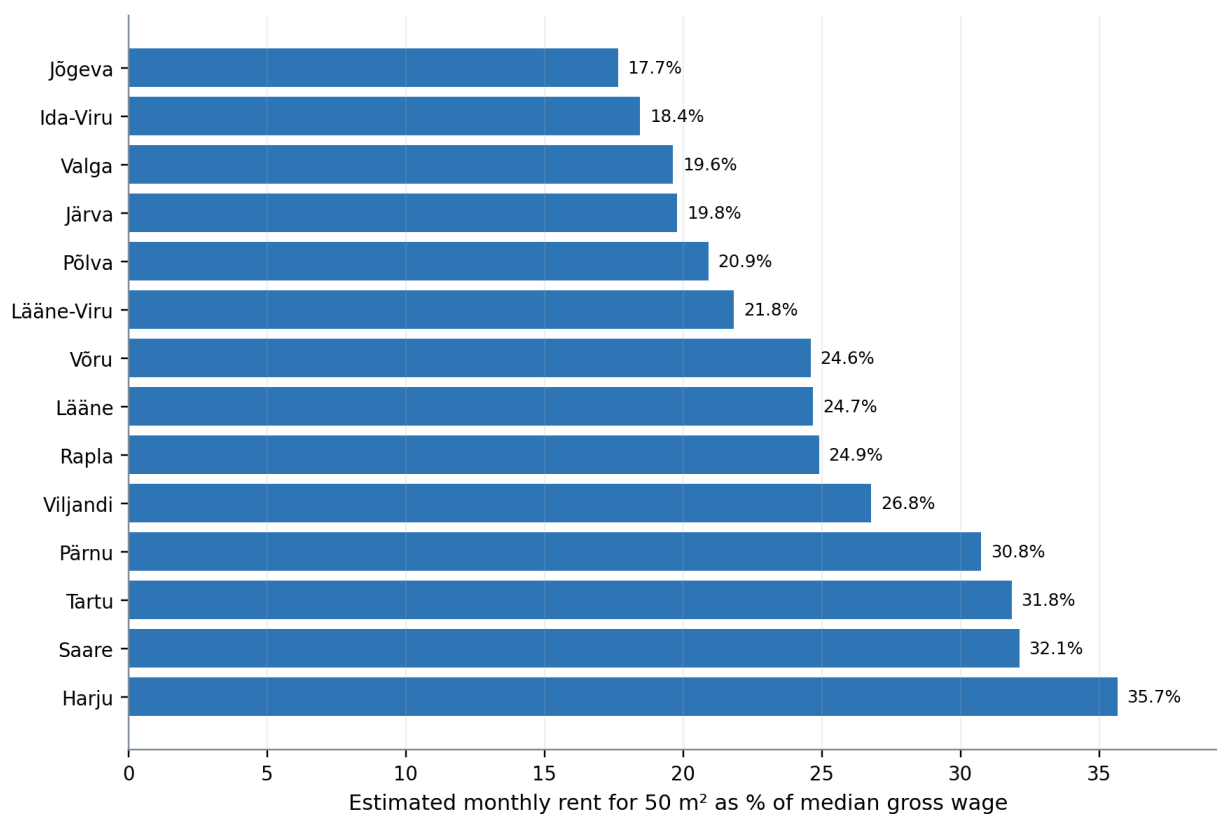
Figure 2. Percentile component scores for ranked counties.

Source: Derived county score model; all scores are relative percentiles.

3.3 Housing affordability separates the large centres from smaller counties

The estimated rent burden ranges from 17.7% of median gross wage in Jõgeva to 35.7% in Harju. Ida-Viru, Valga and Järva also remain below 20%. Pärnu, Tartu, Saare and Harju exceed 30%. Because the denominator is gross wage, these percentages understate the burden relative to take-home income.

Rental burden varies from 17.7% to 35.7% of gross median wage

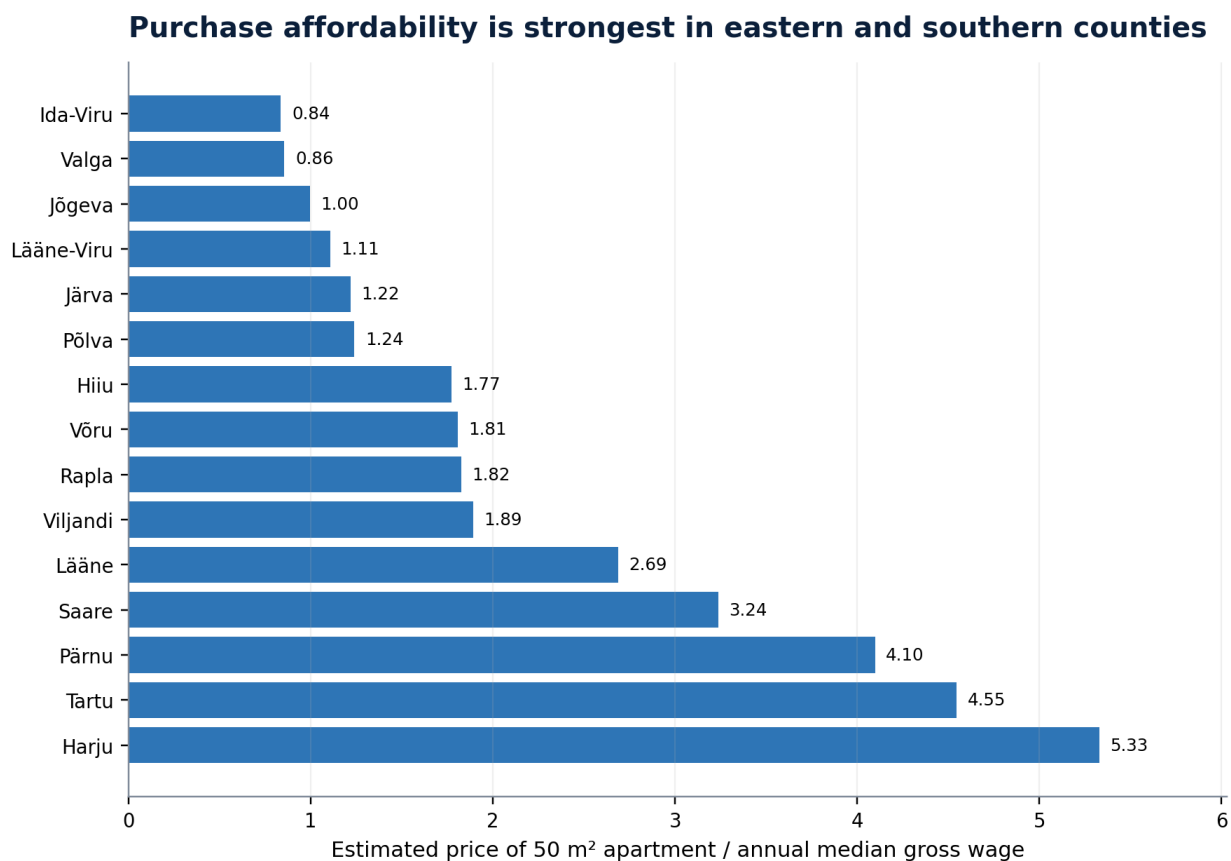


Scenario: 50 m² apartment. Asking rents from KV.ee; denominator is gross, not net, wage.

Figure 3. Estimated rental burden for a 50 m² apartment.

Source: KV.ee asking-rent statistics and Statistics Estonia PA119.

Purchase affordability shows an even wider spread. A 50 m² apartment is equivalent to 0.84 annual median gross wages in Ida-Viru and 0.86 in Valga, compared with 5.33 in Harju and 4.55 in Tartu. This comparison is structural rather than current: the apartment-price numerator is a cumulative 2021–2025 transaction median.



Transaction prices are cumulative medians for 2021–2025, not current monthly prices.

Figure 4. Estimated 50 m² apartment price relative to annual median gross wage.

Source: Maa- ja Ruumiamet apartment transactions and Statistics Estonia PA119.

3.4 Labour-market leaders differ by criterion

Harju has the highest wage (€1,992 per month) and the highest latest four-quarter vacancy rate (2.13%). Tartu combines the second-highest wage (€1,860) with 5.2% unemployment, but its vacancy rate is below the county median. Viljandi has the lowest unemployment rate at 4.8%, followed by Võru at 5.0%. Jõgeva has a strong vacancy rate of 1.88% but a high unemployment rate of 9.3%.



Figure 5. Labour-market trade-offs by county.

Source: Statistics Estonia PA119, TT443 and PAV014.

Median gross wages increased in every county between the 2021 average and the latest 12-month average. Growth ranges from 35.6% in Lääne to 47.3% in Ida-Viru. The increase reflects nominal wages and is not adjusted for inflation.

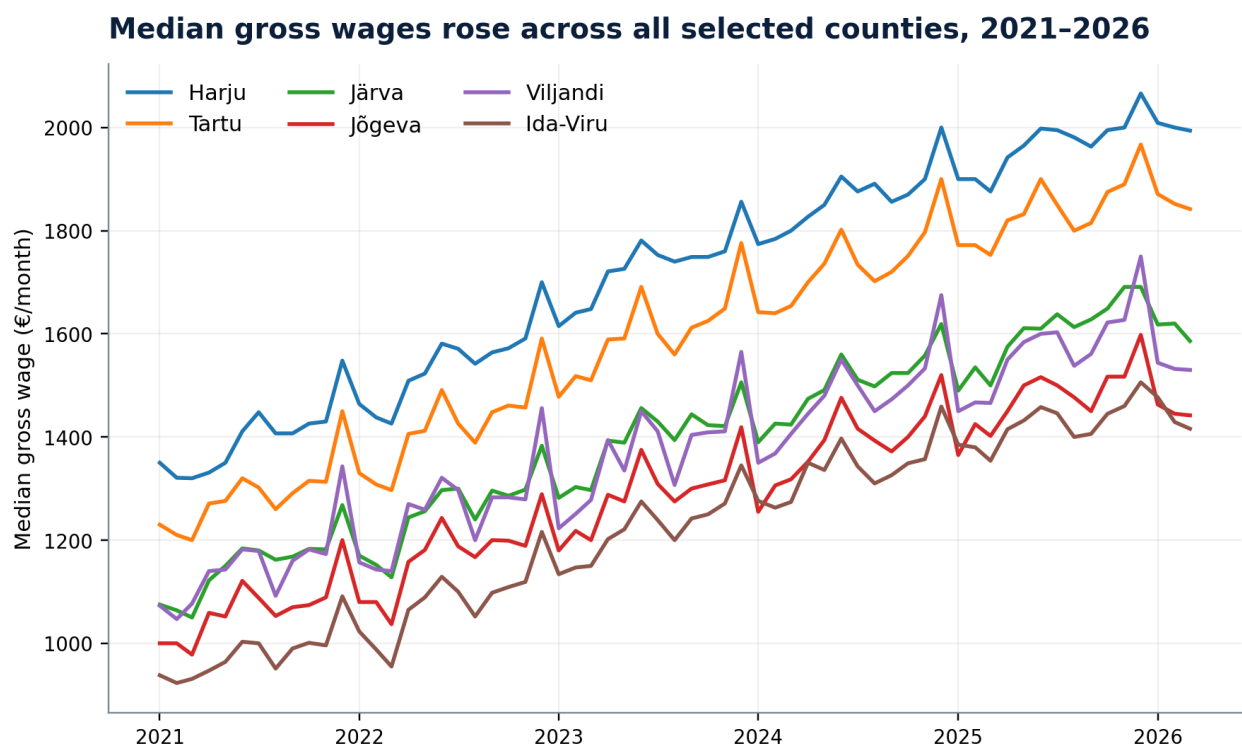


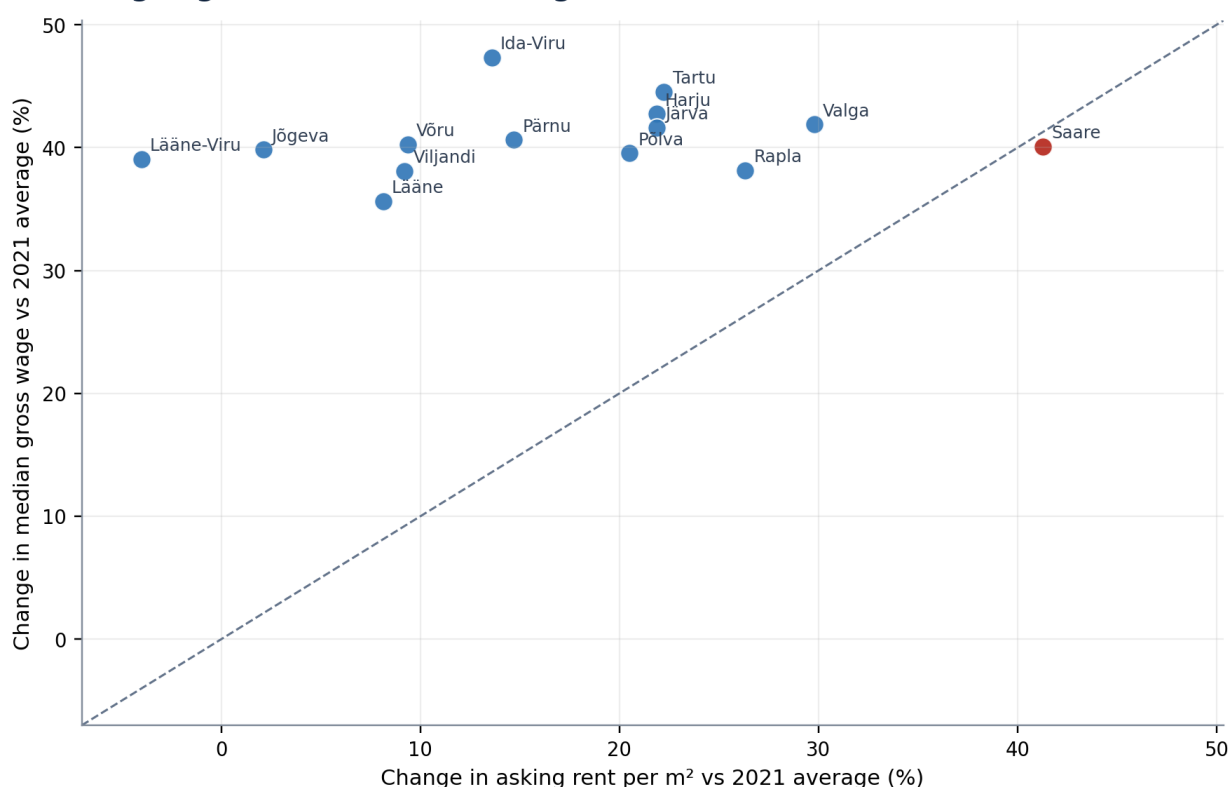
Figure 6. Median gross-wage trend in selected counties, 2021–2026.

Source: Statistics Estonia PA119.

3.5 Wages generally grew faster than asking rents

Compared with the 2021 average, median gross wages grew faster than apartment asking rents in 13 of the 14 counties with rent observations. The largest gaps appear in Lääne-Viru, Jõgeva and Ida-Viru. Saare is the only county where rent growth slightly exceeded wage growth, but only seven recent rent months are available and the market has low listing depth. The result should therefore be treated as indicative.

Wages grew faster than asking rents in 13 of 14 counties with rent data



Points above the diagonal indicate improving gross-wage rental affordability. Saare has low data confidence.

Figure 7. Wage growth versus asking-rent growth since 2021.

Source: Statistics Estonia PA119 and KV.ee price statistics.

3.6 Sensitivity analysis: Järva is stable; several other ranks are not

The baseline weights are not objective facts. Four plausible scenarios were tested: baseline, affordability-focused, labour-market-focused and income-focused. Järva remains first in every scenario. Harju moves between second and twelfth, demonstrating that its position depends heavily on whether the user prioritises labour-market strength or housing affordability. Jõgeva ranges from second to eighth; Viljandi ranges from third to eighth.

Table 4. Top five counties under alternative weighting scenarios

Rank	Baseline	Affordability-focused	Labour-market-focused	Income-focused
1	Järva (79.0)	Järva (78.0)	Järva (78.8)	Järva (80.5)
2	Põlva (65.0)	Jõgeva (74.1)	Harju (74.3)	Harju (66.2)
3	Jõgeva (64.9)	Põlva (66.7)	Viljandi (67.6)	Viljandi (64.1)
4	Viljandi (60.9)	Ida-Viru (65.2)	Võru (66.9)	Põlva (62.5)
5	Võru (59.5)	Valga (63.9)	Põlva (64.2)	Tartu (60.8)

Source: Sensitivity analysis uses the same component scores with alternative weights; Hiiu remains excluded.

3.7 Data quality limits two island counties

Hiiu cannot receive a strict overall score because the supplied KV.ee files contain no apartment-rent observations and TT443 contains no 2024 county value. These fields are recorded as missing, not zero. Saare has all required components but only seven recent rent months and an average of roughly ten advertisements per month; it is therefore marked low confidence. The remaining 13 ranked counties are high confidence, except Põlva, which is medium confidence because its recent rental market is small.

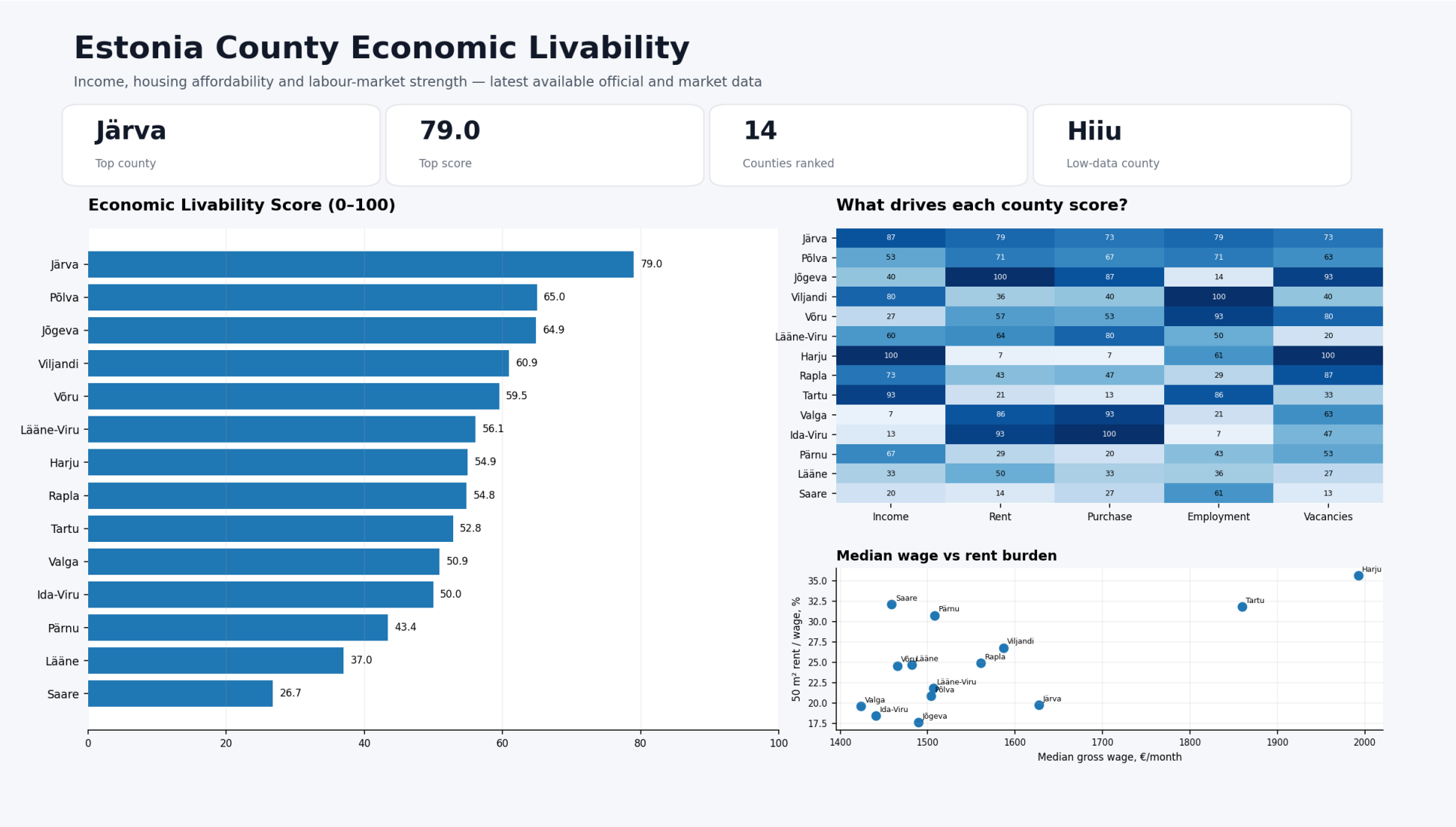
4. Power BI Report Design

The interactive Power BI report is designed as a five-page decision tool. The first three pages have been prototyped using the prepared data. The images below are data-driven design mockups, not screenshots of a completed PBIP file.

The design follows three rules: the central decision question is visible on the first page; each visual answers a defined analytical question; and data-confidence warnings are shown next to the result rather than hidden in a methodology page.

4.1 Executive Overview

The overview page presents the headline result, ranked county bars, component-score heatmap and a wage-versus-rent-burden trade-off. It also identifies the number of counties ranked and the low-data county.



4.2 Housing Affordability

The housing page separates rental asking prices from completed apartment transactions. It presents rent burden, purchase price-to-income ratio and asking-rent trends, with explicit units and source-period labels.

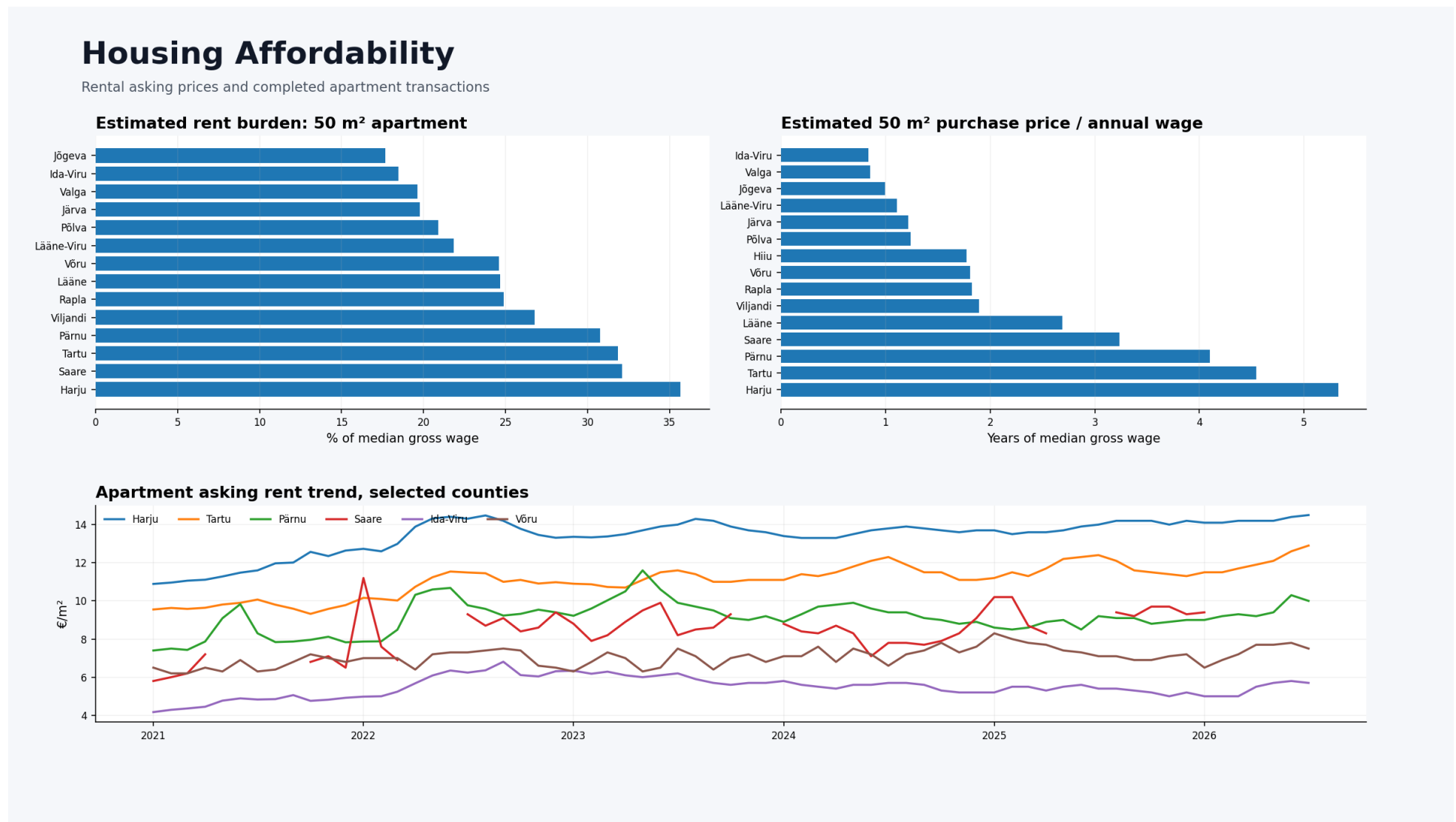


Figure 9. Housing Affordability page prototype.

4.3 Labour Market

The labour-market page combines wage level, unemployment and vacancy rate. The purpose is to distinguish counties with strong incomes from counties with low joblessness or strong employer demand.

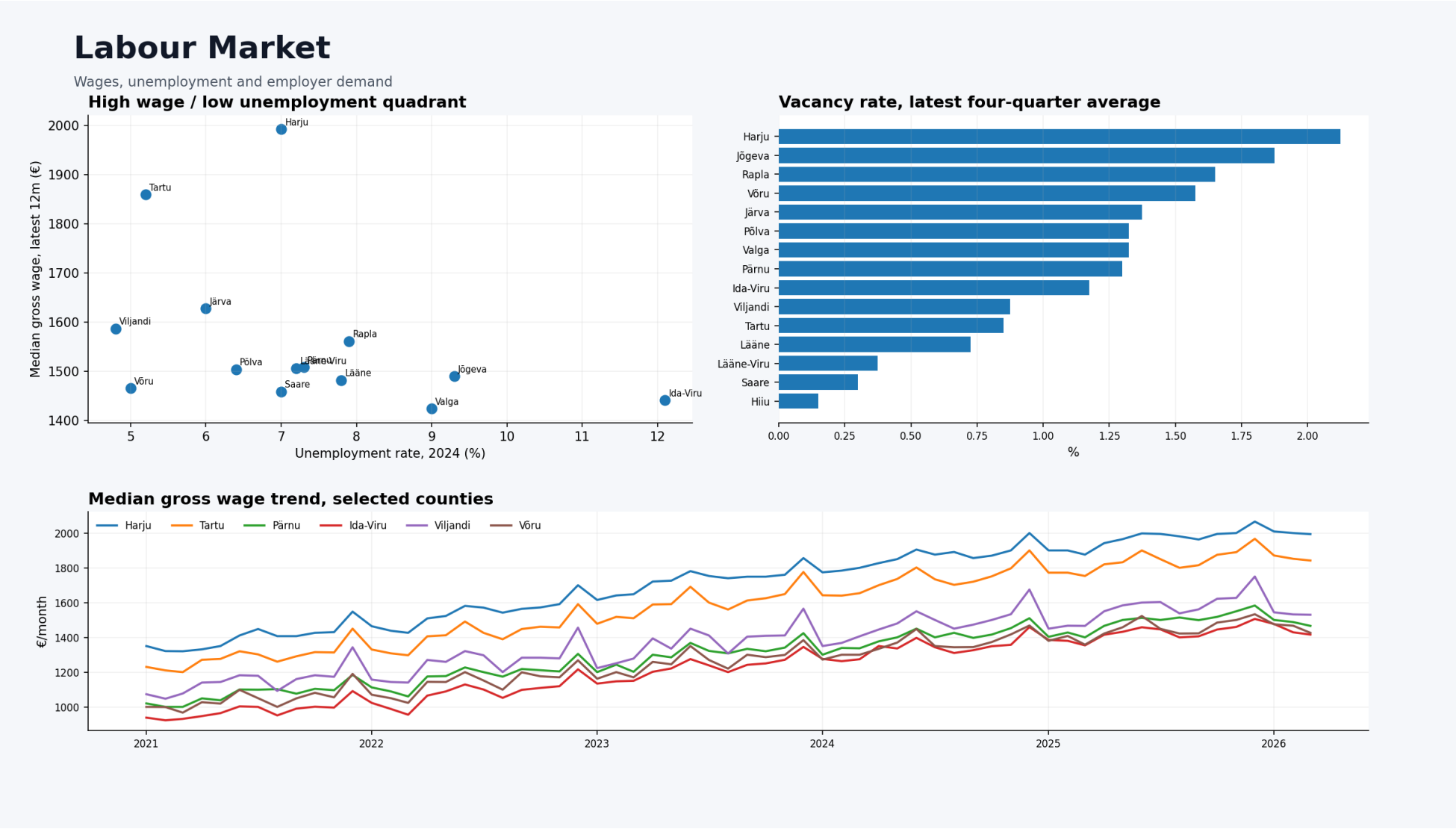


Figure 10. Labour Market page prototype.

4.4 Remaining report pages

- County Profile: selected-county KPIs, trends, peer comparison and data-confidence status.
- Methodology and Data Quality: formulas, source periods, weights, missing-data rules and source links.

The final geographic page should use an official county boundary file. A map should not be created from approximate coordinates or manually drawn shapes.

5. Conclusions and Recommendations

Järva is the strongest balanced result in the current model. It does not lead any single headline metric, but it avoids the major weaknesses that reduce the scores of other counties. The result is robust to substantial changes in component weights.

Harju and Tartu are the strongest choices when high wages are the primary criterion, but both require accepting substantially higher housing costs. Jõgeva, Ida-Viru and Valga offer the strongest housing affordability, although labour-market risk differs sharply: Jõgeva and Ida-Viru have high unemployment values, while Valga combines low costs with a weaker overall opportunity profile. Viljandi offers the strongest employment-security result but not the strongest vacancy rate.

The report should be used to create a shortlist rather than a final relocation decision. A county-level choice should be followed by municipality-level analysis and a household budget based on net income, actual dwelling size, utilities, transport and commuting costs.

Table 5. Recommended interpretation by priority

Priority	Counties to examine first	Reason
Balanced economic conditions	Järva; Põlva; Jõgeva	Highest baseline scores; Järva remains first in all scenarios.
High income and employer demand	Harju; Tartu	Highest wages; Harju also has the highest vacancy rate.
Rental affordability	Jõgeva; Ida-Viru; Valga; Järva	Lowest estimated 50 m ² rent burden relative to gross median wage.
Purchase affordability	Ida-Viru; Valga; Jõgeva; Lääne-Viru	Lowest 50 m ² price-to-income ratios.
Low unemployment	Viljandi; Võru; Tartu	Lowest 2024 three-year moving-average unemployment values.
Insufficient evidence	Hiiu	No rent series and no 2024 unemployment value in the supplied data.

6. Limitations

- The report measures economic livability only. It excludes safety, health, education, public services, environment, transport, internet connectivity and subjective preferences.
- Gross wages are used because county-level net disposable income was not supplied. Rental and purchase burdens relative to take-home income would be higher.
- KV.ee data represent asking prices and listing activity, not completed rental contracts. Listings can be repeated or withdrawn.
- The 50 m² apartment is a standardised scenario. Actual housing needs and prices vary by municipality, condition, building type and dwelling size.
- Apartment purchase prices are cumulative 2021–2025 medians, while wages use the latest 12 months through March 2026. This mixes reference periods.
- TT443 reports a three-year moving-average unemployment rate. It is suitable for stable county comparison but does not measure current monthly unemployment.
- Percentile scores are relative to the counties included. Data revisions or a different county set can change component scores even when raw values do not change.
- The weighting model reflects an analytical choice. The sensitivity analysis reduces, but does not remove, this subjectivity.
- Hiiu is unranked and Saare is low confidence. The absence of rental observations must not be interpreted as zero rent or perfect affordability.

References

- [1] Statistics Estonia. PA119: Average monthly gross wages, median and number of employees by county (monthly). https://andmed.stat.ee/en/stat/majandus__palk-ja-toojeukulu__palk__luhiajastatistika/PA119
- [2] Statistics Estonia. TT443: Unemployment rate (three-year moving average) by county. https://andmed.stat.ee/en/stat/sotsiaalelu__tooturg__tootud__aastastatistika/TT443
- [3] Statistics Estonia. PAV014: Job vacancies and occupied posts by county (quarterly). https://andmed.stat.ee/en/stat/majandus__palk-ja-toojeukulu__vabad-ametikohad/PAV014
- [4] Statistics Estonia. RV022U: Population by sex, age group, ethnic nationality and county, 1 January. https://andmed.stat.ee/en/stat/rahvastik__rahvastikunaitajad-ja-koosseis__rahvaarv-ja-rahvastiku-koosseis/RV022U
- [5] KV.ee. Price statistics: apartment asking prices and listing activity. <https://www.kv.ee/en/hinnastatistika>
- [6] Maa- ja Ruumiamet. Real-estate price-statistics query guide. <https://maaruum.ee/kinnisvara-hinnastatistika-paringu-juhend>
- [7] Maa- ja Ruumiamet. Real-estate transaction statistics. <https://maaruum.ee/en/land-registry-and-land-valuation/real-estate-transactions/real-estate-transaction-statistics>

Appendix A. County Snapshot

The table reports the exact inputs used in the baseline snapshot. Hiiu is included but has no overall score. Monetary values are rounded for presentation.

Rank	County	Score	Median wage €/m	Rent burden %	Purchase ratio	Unemployment %	Vacancy %	Confidence
1	Järva	79.0	1,628	19.8	1.22	6.0	1.38	High
2	Põlva	65.0	1,504	20.9	1.24	6.4	1.32	Medium
3	Jõgeva	64.9	1,490	17.7	1.00	9.3	1.88	High
4	Viljandi	60.9	1,587	26.8	1.89	4.8	0.88	High
5	Võru	59.5	1,465	24.6	1.81	5.0	1.57	High
6	Lääne-Viru	56.1	1,506	21.8	1.11	7.2	0.38	High
7	Harju	54.9	1,992	35.7	5.33	7.0	2.12	High
8	Rapla	54.8	1,561	24.9	1.82	7.9	1.65	High

Appendix A. County Snapshot (continued)

Rank	County	Score	Median wage €/m	Rent burden %	Purchase ratio	Unemployment %	Vacancy %	Confidence
9	Tartu	52.8	1,860	31.8	4.55	5.2	0.85	High
10	Valga	50.9	1,424	19.6	0.86	9.0	1.32	High
11	Ida-Viru	50.0	1,441	18.4	0.84	12.1	1.18	High
12	Pärnu	43.4	1,508	30.8	4.10	7.3	1.30	High
13	Lääne	37.0	1,482	24.7	2.69	7.8	0.72	High
14	Saare	26.7	1,459	32.1	3.24	7.0	0.30	Low
—	Hiiu	—	1,493	—	1.77	—	0.15	Low

Source: County snapshot derived from the six datasets listed in Table 2.

Appendix B. Sensitivity Analysis

The table shows the rank of each county under four weighting systems. A narrow range indicates a stable result; a wide range indicates that the county's position depends strongly on user priorities.

County	Baseline	Affordability	Labour market	Income	Best rank	Worst rank
Järva	1	1	1	1	1	1
Põlva	2	3	5	4	2	5
Jõgeva	3	2	8	6	2	8
Viljandi	4	8	3	3	3	8
Võru	5	7	4	9	4	9
Lääne-Viru	6	6	10	8	6	10
Harju	7	12	2	2	2	12

Appendix B. Sensitivity Analysis (continued)

County	Baseline	Affordability	Labour market	Income	Best rank	Worst rank
Rapla	8	9	7	7	7	9
Tartu	9	10	6	5	5	10
Valga	10	5	11	12	5	12
Ida-Viru	11	4	12	11	4	12
Pärnu	12	13	9	10	9	13
Lääne	13	11	13	13	11	13
Saare	14	14	14	14	14	14

Source: Alternative weights are documented in Section 3.6. Raw component scores are unchanged.